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Michèle Lamont

How Professors Think. Inside the Curious World of Academic Judgment Harvard, MA:

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Michèle Lamont's *How Professors Think* is an empirical study of peer review panels that evaluate applications for research fellowships. She conducted eighty-one interviews with panel participants as well as with officials of five U.S. American research funding organizations. All these organizations award funds to scholars from the social sciences and humanities. Panels had to rank the submissions according to criteria of excellence as spelled out by the respective funding organization. The exact meaning of these criteria, however, is unclear and contested: not all panelists and officials agree on what terms like, for example, clarity, originality, significance, or quality mean. In other words, these terms do not *per se* allow for clear and transparent decisions on how to rank scholarly work. It takes a process of group discussion for panel members to reach an agreement about which proposal is excellent and which is not, thereby continuously reasoning about excellence, negotiating its actual content, and weighing up its different criteria (clarity, significance, etc.). This situation is aggravated when, as was the case with the panels Lamont studied, the panels are set up by scholars coming from different disciplines.

Lamont's approach to norms is that of the interpretive paradigm of sociology (as opposed to the normative paradigm): Norms exist, but what they actually mean in relation to a given phenomenon is a matter of interpretation (and discussion). Arguing that peer "evaluation is not based on stable comparables, and that various competing criteria with multiple meanings are used to assess academic work" (p. 18), she tries to investigate how the meaning of scientific norms is created in the interactive processes that

characterize panel deliberations. After an introductory chapter (“Opening the Black Box of Peer Review,” pp. 1-21) that sums up the central arguments of the book, Lamont describes the formal and informal tasks of program officers, discusses how panel members are selected and what is expected from them, and gives an overview over the evaluation criteria as formulated by the funding organizations involved in the study (“How Panels Work,” pp. 22-52). The chapter that follows (“On Disciplinary Cultures,” pp. 53-106) consists mainly of descriptions of the actual situation in America of the disciplines of concern: philosophy, English literature, history, anthropology, political science, and economics. Lamont argues that each of these disciplines has its own approach to defining excellence that can be related both to its recent past and its current status; clearly, these different approaches can cause conflict in the course of deliberations.

Although panel members take different approaches to defining excellence, panels actually do reach a consensus on applications, as it is described in chapter 4 (“Pragmatic Fairness: Customary Rules of Deliberation,” pp. 107-58). Lamont describes several rules panels appear to follow. Chief among these rules is the rule of cognitive contextualization, which means that applications are evaluated according to the criteria of the discipline from which they originate. Although scholars usually come to the panel deliberations with a picture of excellence that reflects their disciplinary contexts, they are—for the most part, and under certain conditions—ready to respect the sovereignty of other disciplines and defer to the expertise of other disciplines. The world Lamont describes “is not one where elites from different evaluative regimes mutually bless one another, nor is it one where narrow social networks coordinate their efforts to engage in opportunity hoarding” (p. 156). Contesting other approaches to the academic world and the relations between disciplines, above all the one applied by Pierre Bourdieu (1988), Lamont finds that scholars are willing to accept other standards of excellence, to respect the equal status of other disciplines and to acknowledge that there is excellence outside one’s own discipline. Under the condition that the rules, which are hardly explicitly stated, are followed, the deliberation process itself constitutes a source of trust in the peer review system on behalf of the panel members.

After thus having identified rules that implicitly guide the deliberation process, Lamont turns to the question how scholars evaluate the proposals (Chapter 5, “Recognizing Various Kinds of Excellence,” pp. 159-201). She argues that the disciplines involved show different epistemological styles, which she defines as “preferences for particular ways of understanding how to build knowledge, as well as beliefs in the very possibility of proving

those theories” (p. 54). Lamont mentions four epistemological styles that arose out of a detailed content analysis of the interviews done by her and her colleagues Grégoire Mallard and Joshua Guetzkow: comprehensive, constructivist, positivist, and utilitarian. In *How Professors Think*, these styles are described only *en passant* (the reader may turn to Mallard, Lamont, and Guetzkow 2009). In short, the comprehensive style “values verstehen, attention to details, and contextual specificity” (p. 57); the constructivist style “emphasizes proposals that ‘give voice’ to various groups” (p. 57); the positivist style “favors generalizability and hypothesis testing” (p. 57); and, finally, the utilitarian style “values only the production of instrumental knowledge” (p. 58). While the comprehensive epistemological style is dominant in all the three disciplinary clusters—humanities (86%; multiple categorization of an interviewee was possible; see table 5.6, p. 177), history (78%), and social sciences (71%)—there are differences in the extent to which the other styles could be found. While none of the representatives of humanities could be assigned to the positivist and the utilitarian styles, this was the case with history (23% and 4%) and even more clearly with the social sciences (57% and 19%). The constructive style is adopted twice as much in the humanities (28%) and in history (29%) than it is in the social sciences (14%).

Clearly, these epistemological styles have consequences for how research proposals are evaluated. While, for instance, the majority of humanists (33%; no multiple categorization; see table 5.3, p. 174) and of historians (43%) refer to the approach of a given proposal when having to judge its originality, social scientists mainly turn to the method (27%). Many other criteria are discussed in such detail, always without making this chapter a boring read. Interestingly, moreover, Lamont also discusses criteria the panels are not explicitly expected to judge but that, according to her research, also play an important role in getting a picture of the proposal and the person behind it. These “informal, evanescent criteria” (p. 187) include signs of intelligence, elegance, cultural capital, as well as moral qualities of the applicant. Furthermore, some funding organizations and reviewers also favor criteria that somehow counter the idea of excellence by expecting interdisciplinarity and diversity (Chapter 6, “Considering Interdisciplinarity and Diversity,” pp. 202-38). Lamont concludes that, despite all efforts, personal preferences and idiosyncrasies of the reviewers play an important and, in Lamont’s view, unavoidable role: the technology of deliberation, with all the customary rules as described in chapter 4, cannot level out personal preferences, mainly because “Academia is a highly variegated world, one where qualitatively incommensurate proposals cannot be subsumed

under a single standard” (p. 200). The system of peer review is not perfect, and “it is true that, at the end of the day, we cannot know for sure whether the “cream rises.” However, if panelists believe that it does, and make considerable sacrifices to do a good job, they contribute to sustaining a relatively meritocratic system” (p. 243).

If, in this context, anything critical should be said of the book, then it would be that the title is misleading. Read as alluding to Mary Douglas’ *How Institutions Think* (Douglas 1996), it gives rise to expectations that are not fulfilled. Apart from a reference to Ludwik Fleck, these two books have little in common. While Douglas was concerned with integrating, on a very abstract theoretical level, positions from the sociology of institutions and the sociology of knowledge, Lamont’s focus is on empirically investigating a social phenomenon. She is content with giving factual answers to questions that, without any doubt and clearly pronounced throughout the book, have theoretical significance, but she does not come up with a new, profound theoretical approach herself. However, Lamont announces as her next step a general theory of valuation (p. 249)—perhaps, this would have been the right book for the title.

To conclude, the book is a captive read. It is well written, above all because the technical parts of the text—references, summaries, and critical evaluations of other texts—are banned into notes at the end of the book. The consequent use of an interpretive approach to norms—Lamont herself refers mainly to Erving Goffman—is a very valuable feature of the book, as it allows her to see, for instance, that “Reviewers’ very real desire to have their opinion respected by their colleagues also plays an important role in deliberations” (p. 8). Also, her considerations of problems that arise when exporting this model of academic evaluation outside the U.S. (pp. 243-5) are very enlightening.

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